

ISYS90045 Professional IS Consulting

Seminar 2* Preparing Proposals – Understanding your Audience

Dr Marc Cheong

(Based on contributions by Dr Rod Dilnutt;
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Dr Piya Shedden; Chris Waddell; et al)

WARNING

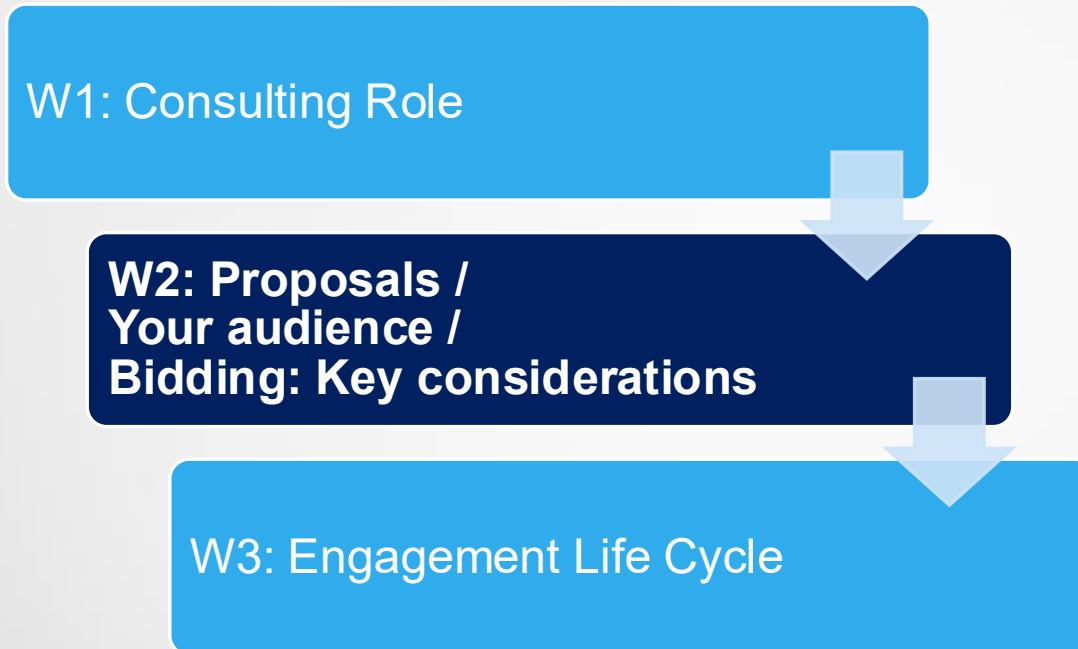
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Timeline



There will be some overlap between W2 and W3:
W2 will focus mainly on proposals, your audience, and key considerations BEFORE you even win the work...
W3 will continue the discussion on lifecycles of consulting engagements.

Housekeeping

A note for Thursday students

- Apologies for the timetabling issue – we're urgently liaising with Admin to finalise the classes.
- Please stay tuned to Canvas Announcements and your own University Timetable for updates before your class.

AT1 notes – slides overleaf

- AT1 timeline
- AT1 Canvas resources

AT1 Timeline

Assignment AT1 is approaching!

**AT1 is composed of 2 parts: A01a Presentation and A01b Report.
Please check Canvas and stay tuned for comms.**

**Now: You need to find colleagues to form pair groups
(= 2 consultants per group) ASAP.**

**Please organise into pairs for assignment AT1.
Currently we only have about 15 students of 72 that are in a group.**

W4: Please be sure to attend the lecture in W4 as Christina will be giving a briefing on AT1, and Marc will lecture on Presentations.

W5: Your AT1 presentation.

AT1 Canvas Resources

ISYS90045 2026 SM1 > Assignments

2026 Semester 1

Home
Subject Overview
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Ed Discussion
Modules
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▼ [AT1] Assignment A01a and b Pairs presentation, 1 minutes duration and Report (7-8 Hours (of work required))

Assignment A01a Pairs Presentation, 1 or 3 minutes duration (7-8 Hours of work required)
Available until Apr 16 at 17:00 | Due Apr 1 at 10:00 | 5 pts

Assignment A01b Pairs Report of approximately 1000 words (7-8 Hours of work required)
Available until Apr 24 at 23:59 | Due Apr 17 at 23:59 | 15 pts

ISYS90045 2026 SM1 > People > Groups

Ed Discussion
Modules
Lecture Capture
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Everyone A1 Pair

Self sign-up is enabled for these groups. ?
Groups are limited to 2 members.

Unassigned Students (51) Groups (40)

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New Thread

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COURSES +
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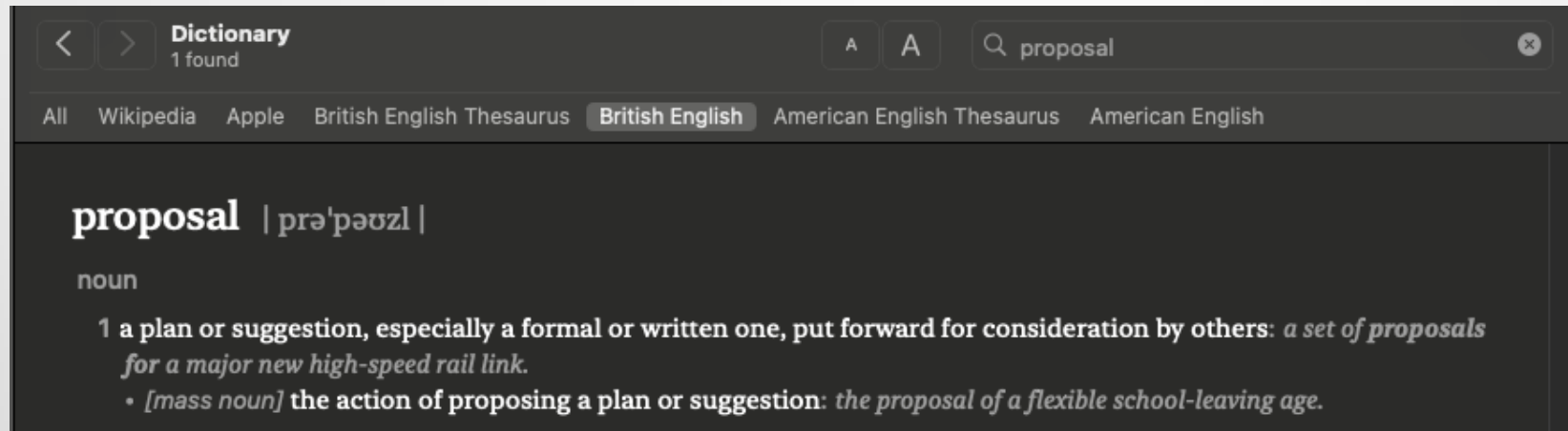
CATEGORIES
General
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Tutorials
Weekly Discussion Sce...
Assignments
AT1

Assignment AT1 (A01a + A01b) Group Finder
Assignments - AT1 Marc Cheong STAFF 10m

Assignment AT1 (A01a + A01b) Queries
Assignments - AT1 Marc Cheong STAFF 11m

Show less

Agenda: Proposals



Understanding what proposals are
Comparing between types of proposals
Understanding the basic structure of a proposal

Proposals: At-a-glance



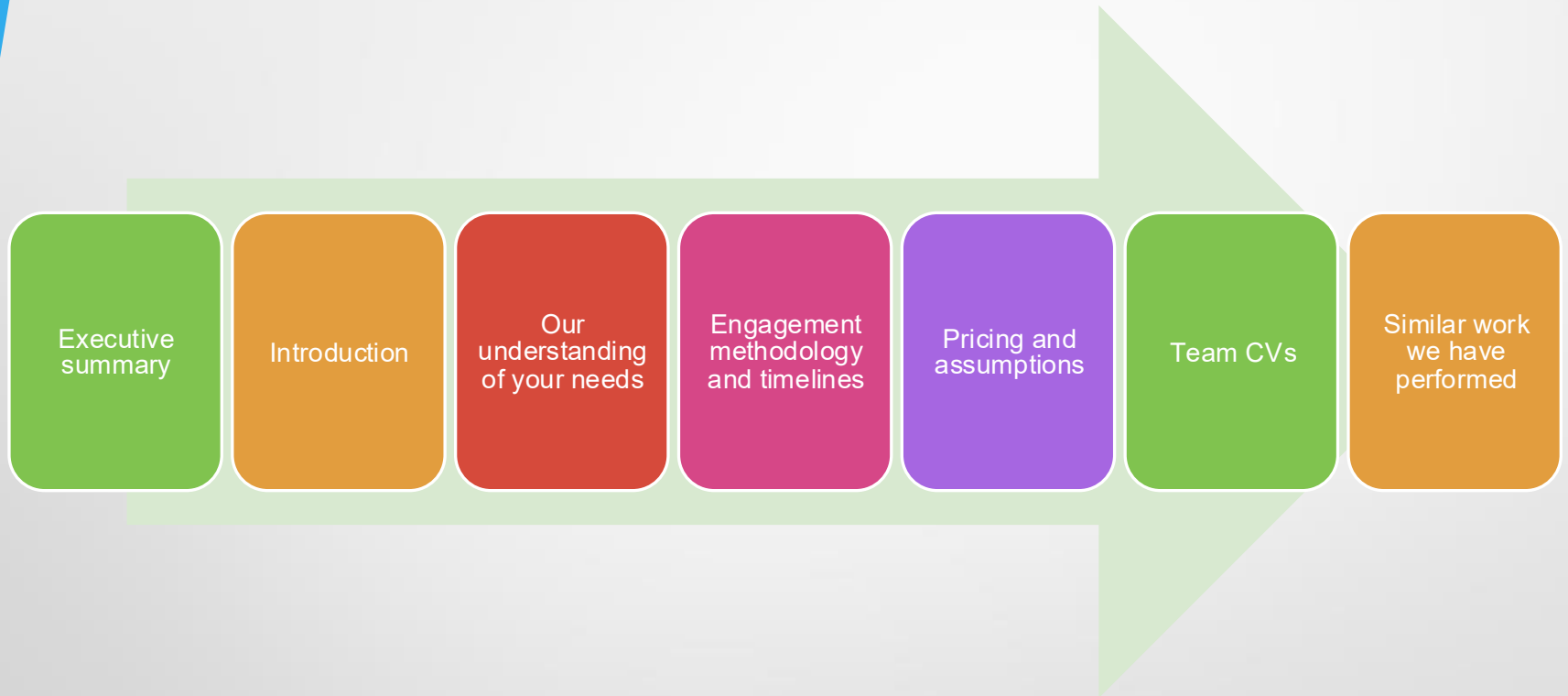
Jordyn, B. (2018). 4 Parts of the Perfect Consulting Proposal.
Accelera Consulting Group/The Consultants Institute/YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eZ59JCMoi6I>

Proposals

What is a proposal?

- Written offers from a potential seller to a client
- Contains (amongst other things):
 - A summary of services to offer
 - Expression of the business problem to be solved
 - Budget
 - Team
 - (*...you get to practice in AT2*).

Proposals: At-a-glance



▶ Exercise: Assign the audience: Suppose **you** are (a) the potential client OR (b) the potential consultant.



Scenario: Suppose the prospective client is a family retail business (MyGrocer – 10 branches in Melbourne, ~10 staff per branch), and they'd like to engage a consultancy to migrate email (SaaS) from Office365 to Google Apps (because they are sick of Copilot 😊)

Proposals

- Can be in any format
 -  **Exercise: What formats are common for a proposal?**
- Proposal writing can be a full-time job!
 - Experts on engagement methodology
 - Deep technical and industry specialisations
 - Knowledge of the sales process.
- **Even bids for smaller engagements can take days to prepare!**
 - **Who does the work?**
 - *(More later...)*

Proposals: Formal or informal?

- When is a formal proposal required?
 - In response to a formal request out to the market
 - Often required for public sector
 - Or if the expected cost is above internal budget
- When can an informal proposal result?
 - Direct approach, via relationships with client
 - If informal may be arranged through:
 - Providing high-level material on budget, methodology
 - Moving directly to an engagement letter/ contract
 - Verbal agreement?

Proposals: Types

Type	Description
Request for information (RFI)	High-level request by a client to understand what products and services are in the market.
Expression of interest (EOI)	Used to test supplier interest (inviting suppliers to submit future proposals).
Request for quote (RFQ)	More focused on pricing and price-per-unit (more for standardised or commoditized services).
Request for tender (RFT)	Formal request by a client for potential suppliers to submit bids. Commonly used by Government Agencies.
Request for proposal (RFP)	As per the RFT, but for private entities

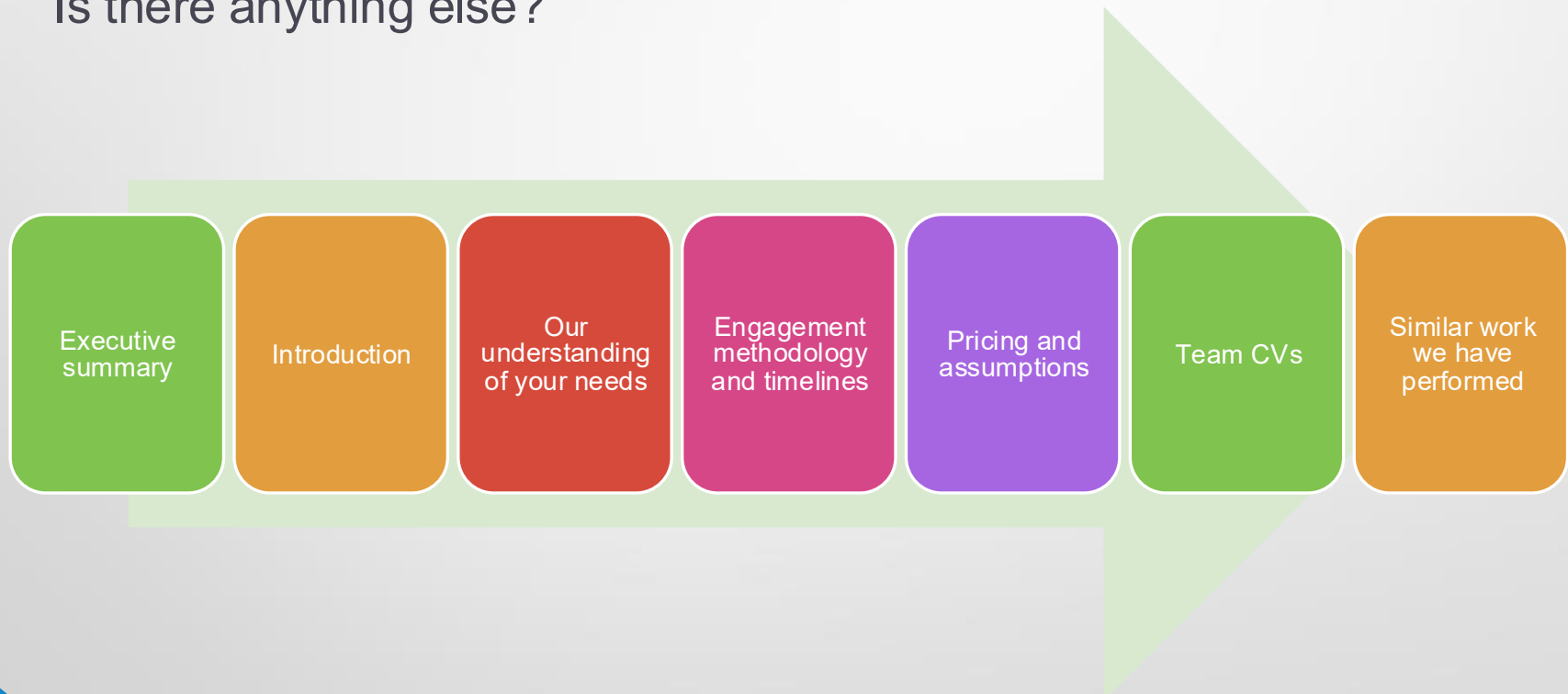
Structure of a proposal

- Avoid clutter
- A well-structured proposal:
 - Is easy to read and navigate
 - Assists the client in properly evaluating the proposal
- If you have detailed technical specifications, then include them as appendices
- Use diagrams and pictures to aid understanding of complex elements.

Structure of a proposal

What goes into a good proposal?

Is there anything else?



Structure of a proposal (1/4)

 Executive summary	• Covers main points of your proposal • Is a summary: NOT an introduction • Consider: an academic paper abstract.
 Introduction	• Present the background and scope of the work requested • Present the structure of the proposal • Outline how you're suited for this work • Also a good opportunity to raise prior work performed.

Structure of a proposal (2/4)

 Our understanding of your needs	• A description of your interpretation of the request • What does the client want? • What is the real issue that you're looking to solve • Don't just restate their text from the RFT/ RFP!
 Engagement methodology and timelines	• What is your special recipe for doing this work? • What is the actual process for doing this work? • How will you present it? • Funky Gantt Charts, milestones, icons? • Project governance structures • Assumptions • Pricing

Structure of a proposal (3/4)

 Pricing and assumptions	• What is your total price? • Is there a budget the client has in mind? • How much are you telling the client in your costing? • Are there any discounts you can apply? • What assumptions have you based this on (e.g. limits on number of workshops, certain activities you're not doing, you're only performing a high-level study, etc)?
 Team CVs	• Who is going to be doing the work? • Structure of the engagement team (roles, responsibilities, job titles) • Who is 'actually' going to be doing the work? • Descriptions of what people's expertise is, past engagements, etc.

Structure of a proposal (4/4)

Similar work
we have
performed

- Tell stories so you can demonstrate your expertise in the space
- What are the big success stories for your organisation in doing similar work?
- Who did you do it for, how did you do it?
- What were the benefits?



Exercise: Pay attention to the details!

Scenario adapted from The National Learning Consortium (2012).

You are preparing a proposal in response to an sample RfP by the National Learning Consortium.

[Source:

<https://www.compasshcc.org/filesimages/Tools/Pop%20Health/SIM/SDOH%20Toolkit/11.%20NLC-Request-For-Proposal-Template-Health-Information-Technology.pdf>]

Scan this QR code for the sample RfP, and turn to page 8.





Exercise: Pay attention to the details!

Scenario adapted from The National Learning Consortium (2012).
Your small consultancy, ISConsultants, has just been acquired by Salesforce (yay!). You are a partner at ISConsultants.
You and your team are preparing a proposal in response.

General

ISConsultants Ltd. (A Salesforce company)

Trading at: 123 Fake St Melbourne 3000 VIC.

Web: www.professionalISconsulting.example.com

Main Contact

Joe Bloggs, Partner

123 Fake St Melbourne 3000 VIC

PO Box 67 General Post Office Melbourne 3000 VIC

Market Data:

Number of years as EHR vendor: 6

Number of live sites: 7 [...continued...]

Proposals: Pay attention to the details!

- Make sure you satisfy all essential criteria
- Ensure you include all requested sections including:
 - Company details and address
 - Insurance certificates
 - Staff references
 - Relevant qualifications and case studies
- Watch out for any price cap.
- **You do not want to be knocked out because you forgot to include some requested element!**
- Initial proposal evaluation will likely be done by functional staff as a 'box ticking exercise'.
 - These knock out proposals that miss criteria.

Agenda: Proposals ...and Your Audience



Understanding how to tailor proposals to your target audience.
Understanding how stakeholders will react to the proposal.

Please see also:
Supplementary slides on Understanding your Audience
(credits: to Rod and Christina)



Exercise: How to 'sell' your proposal?

What makes a 'good sale'? Think about a time where you were sold something – anything!

Then discuss:

- What were you buying?
- What made you complete the transaction?
- Did you actually want it?

Your Audience: Know your audience

Like a presentation, know your audience for a proposal

We write these for clients. Consider:



Who are they?

- May impact language, content, style, information presented, industry experience.



What do they want?

- What is the client asking for?
- What is the best way we can solve this problem for them?



What don't they want?

- Do we sell them something they don't want or need?

Your Audience: What to Include?

Remember:

- The final decision makers will likely be senior
- They will refer your proposal to functional staff for evaluation of technical aspects

“Should the proposal contain technical details?”

- Answer: It depends on the client
- Are they technically-focused or –minded?
- If the client is an engineering firm, defence, aircraft, or electricity company then “**yes**”!
 - They will want lots of technical information.

Your Audience: Before you submit your proposal...

Ask to meet the client

- If you can walk the client through the major points of your proposal
- Test their reactions
- Good indicators for your approach, budget, team, etc

Some government organisations will only permit proposal briefings to all bidders to avoid being accused of favouritism

- Likewise for responses to questions
- Can be highly structured (e.g. dates for submission of questions).

Agenda: Proposals

Key Considerations – Should we bid?



Understanding pre-bid activities
Considering risk and effort versus potential reward

Should we bid?

Before you bid...

Typically require a few things to happen first:

- Is there risk in taking this work on?
- How will we mitigate these risks?
- Enter the sale into your CRM (visibility over pipeline)
- Inform your internal lead partner (if there is one)
- **Who will be your team?**

Can we win the bid?

Recall: **“Even bids for smaller engagements can take days to prepare!”**

- Proposal effort takes significant effort
- This is hard if you’re also doing your full-time job!

Should we bid?

Can you win the bid?

Ultimately, will this be worth our time and investment?

- Do we know the client?
- What do we know about their organisation?
- Did we know about the job before the RFP came out?
- What is the work 'really' about?
- Is there potentially more risk than reward?
 -  **Exercise: Who are we competing with?**

Some consulting organisations will not bid if they don't have a relationship with the client.

Should we bid?

Big Wins come in stages

The first objective is to make the shortlist

- It is unlikely that a decision will be made by the client in one pass of the proposals
- There might be a lot of them!
- RFPs/ RFTs require client analysis and shortlisting

If you make the shortlist, the real selling starts!

- You are likely to be asked to make a presentation

If it is a very big contract, then **multiple** submissions and presentations will be required.

If you are chosen, then the contract negotiations begin.

▶ Exercise: Getting started with RfPs.

- The audience divides into 3 groups.



Blue: Digital Advertising
(Silicon Valley Clean
Energy, 2021)

https://www.svcleanenergy.org/wp-content/uploads/SVCE-RFP-Marketing-Advertising-Services_11-12-2021_digital2.pdf



Grey: Data Analytics
(New Jersey City
University, 2017)

https://www.njcu.edu/sites/default/files/17-023_data_analytics_consultant_and_solutions.pdf



Red: Mobile App Dev.
(Hemisfair Park Area
Redevelopment
Corporation, 2021)

<https://hemisfair.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/05.25.2021-RFP-Hemisfair-Augmented-Reality-Project.pdf>



Exercise: Getting started with RfPs.

No need to read in detail – just skim read with your team.

With your chosen case – Energy Advertising/Uni. Analytics/Park App, and from what we've learnt...

- When and how can we ask **questions** to this potential client?
 - Will **responses** to questions be communicated to ALL potential bidders?
- What do you think the potential client is looking out for, in terms of **sector** experience?
- Are **URLs** allowed/compulsory/disallowed in your proposals?
- What kind of **client information/history** do they want as proof of your track record?
- Your firm has current commercial liability **insurance** with a minimum compensation of US\$500,000. Can you bid?
- As we've discussed: "Big Wins come in stages". In your case, do you have to prepare a presentation if you're **shortlisted**?

Proposals – structure

Discussion exercise: Please see Ed Discussion for the full scenario background.

Proposal Structure

Benny Robinson called: he's asking why you haven't submitted your proposal, due very soon!!

You guess he's keen to continue working with your team.

That's good! You let him know that the team are working on it. However, you check in with the Manager that you delegated the bid to... and are shocked to realise the team were re-prioritised to work on a different bid, without you knowing!

It's up to you to prepare a table of contents for a proposal:

- What is your order?
- What will you do in each section?

Week 2: Summary

1. **Proposals** as a key method for winning work.
 - incl. Proposal structure and purpose of each section
2. Know your target **audience** for proposals.
 - incl. Supplementary slides on **Understanding your Audience**
3. **Bidding and pre-bid** activities to consider risk and effort.

Agenda for following weeks:

- Engagement lifecycle and further discussion on proposals
- Presentations (links to AT1/AT2)